

At the Table

A guide to help you sit at the table with Jesus.

Introduction

This document serves as a beacon, illuminating your path as you dine with our Savior, Jesus, amidst life's battles (Psalm 23:5). Try not to focus on "immediate completion", rather, concentrate on one subject each week to prevent overwhelming yourself. This spiritual journey is between you and the Lord; nevertheless, please accept Him as your partner in maintaining your SMART goals.

Below are six elements of life for you to ponder with Jesus. I advise reflecting on only one element per week, or at most two. Each element contains 4-6 aspects for evaluation. Rate each aspect from 1 to 10, jot down the average as your total for that element, and record a sentence explaining your self-assessment.

This exercise is not to provoke feelings of insufficiency or regret. If such feelings emerge, I encourage you to pray against these deceptive whispers of the adversary. Remember, you were divinely crafted for this moment in time, and your current state of being fills our benevolent Father with immeasurable joy. You've made significant strides in your spiritual growth throughout this last season.

This exercise serves as a mirror, reflecting your progress compared to the previous year. Sit with Jesus, ask Him to recall your position in these spheres last year, and base your reflection on that. If you find areas where you've retreated, remember that our Father ceaselessly guides you, holding your right hand. His infinite mercy and grace assure your transition into a more prosperous season next year, as you surrender to Him.

The cited scriptures are not exhaustive but simply those the Lord urged me to include.

Finally, upon completing this reflection, invite the Lord to guide you in devising a six and three-month SMART goal for each sphere.

What makes a goal **SMART**?

- **Specific:** Craft your goal with as much detail and precision as possible.
- **Measurable:** Your goal should be quantifiable to track progress.
- **Achievable:** Ensure your goal aligns with reality.
- **Realistic:** Be truthful with yourself.
- **Time-bound:** Assign a deadline for completion.

Remember, this journey is between you and the Lord. This guide is merely a tool to help you navigate your path toward spiritual growth.

Part One - Preparation

In the following pages, we will delve into six essential elements that form the cornerstone of your spiritual development. Each of these will be subdivided into several categories. Please invite the Holy Spirit's guidance in honestly evaluating yourselves. You will need, a Bible (preferably a physical one since we are seeking to remove all distractions), something to write with, something to write on, and well maybe some tissues!

We initiate this journey with Spiritual Health, synonymous with our relationship with the Father. It takes precedence because, without a solid foundation here, the other elements risk being skewed.

Next, we examine Mental Health, acknowledging its critical role in fulfilling God's will. A sound mind is essential in navigating life's challenges and advancing on our spiritual path.

Third, we consider Emotional Health. Life's ebbs and flows can toss our emotions around like a ship on a stormy sea. While our feelings are genuine, they aren't always the best guides. Still, they should never be silenced, for it's through our emotions that we form deeper connections with others.

Then we focus on Physical Health. To serve the Father to the best of our ability, we need to be healthy. We are called to honor God with our bodies, so maintaining physical health is paramount.

Having explored these four aspects, we then turn our attention to Relationships. This begins with our relationship with God and extends to every person we meet, even during a simple grocery run. Each interaction presents a potential divine encounter.

Finally, we reflect on our Stewardship: how well we manage the blessings God has entrusted to us.

I realize this might seem extensive, perhaps even daunting. However, I assure you, stay the course, sit at the table, and witness the Holy Spirit's transformative power as you invite Him into this sacred moment. Remember that it's easiest to grade yourself by simply putting a number from 1-10 next to each of the subcategories!

Spiritual Health

Assessing Spiritual Health is paramount, as it forms the bedrock of our being. Without a robust spiritual foundation, other aspects of our lives may falter. Our primary purpose is to commune with our Father, for without Him, life lacks meaning. No one and nothing can satisfy our spiritual hunger and thirst but God our Father.

While these aspects don't follow a strict sequence, they interact and influence one another, creating a pathway that aids in our spiritual evolution. It's been my experience that observing the Sabbath sets the foundation for other spiritual disciplines, such as fasting, fostering authentic fellowship, submitting to the Lord's will, and dedicating time to devotion. Without the rest and reflection the Sabbath provides, the other areas become challenging to uphold. This is why they are presented in this order

I invite you to allow the Holy Spirit to speak to you through these and any other areas He may reveal:

1. **Sabbath Keeping (Genesis 2:2-3; Exodus 20: 8-11; Deuteronomy 5:15; Hebrews 4:9-11):**
Recognize that our primary focus is to commune with the Father. Set aside specific time to enjoy His presence, free from work or academic pursuits. It's a moment to simply relish His company.
2. **Obedience (James 2:14-26):**
Faith without action is fruitless. We are called to trust in God and act obediently. Reflect on your responsiveness to God's instructions. How frequently do you heed His word in your life?
3. **Prayer Life (Philippians 4:6-7):**
Reflect on your dialogue with God throughout the day. Consider your divine conversations amid daily tasks, brainstorming, planning, and more.
4. **Devotion (2 Timothy 2:15):**
This is the time devoted solely to God and His Word. It's about deep study, meditation, and research, extending beyond your initial 5-10 minutes with God each morning. Dedicate no less than 25-30 minutes to delve into God's Word, allowing it to examine you as you examine it.
5. **Fasting (Matthew 6:16-18; Exodus 34:28; Acts):**
Understand the principles, commitment, and intentions behind your fast. Fasting isn't just a ritual; it's a dedicated time to seek the Father's face more intimately.
6. **Fellowship (1 Corinthians 12:12-30; Acts):**
Evaluate your community of believers and your motives within that community. Do you engage with the community to make friends or to experience Christ's love in new ways through them? Are your relationships Kingdom-focused and driven?

These are the vital areas to consider when assessing your Spiritual Health. Seek the Holy Spirit's guidance throughout this self-examination and welcome any new insights He may offer. Remember to look up the scriptures, meditate on them, grade yourself in each category, and set SMART goals for each as well!

Mental Health

Mental Health is addressed in several key Bible passages: Romans 12:2, Colossians 3:2, Philippians 2:5, and 2 Corinthians 10:5 (ESV). While mental health encompasses a broad spectrum, the components discussed here are primarily action-based. I encourage further exploration and research into mental health healing and growth for a more comprehensive understanding.

In this reflection, consider the following aspects:

1. Day-to-day resilience (Romans 12:2 ESV):

"Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind, that by testing you may discern what is the will of God, what is good and acceptable and perfect." Assess your ability to handle everyday tasks without any negative bias resulting from past experiences.

2. Healthy Communication (Colossians 3:2 ESV):

"Set your minds on things that are above, not on things that are on earth." Reflect on your ability to express yourself healthily and respectfully with others, even when they may have treated you unfairly or disrespectfully.

3. Healthy Emotional Processing (Philippians 2:5 ESV):

"Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus." Evaluate your capacity to process events and respond healthily, even when things don't unfold as you wish or expect.

4. Openness to Learning and Growth (Proverbs 3:13) "Blessed is the one who finds wisdom, and the one who gets understanding.":

Gauge your willingness to learn and seek personal and spiritual growth. A healthy mental state includes a continuous desire to grow and evolve.

5. Retention Ability (2 Corinthians 10:5 ESV):

"We destroy arguments and every lofty opinion raised against the knowledge of God, and take every thought captive to obey Christ." Assess your ability to retain and apply what you're learning. This includes both spiritual insights and practical life skills.

Remember, this reflection is a tool to help you gain a clearer understanding of your mental health. The Holy Spirit will guide you in this process and help you uncover more areas for growth and healing. Don't forget to grade yourself in each category, and set SMART goals for each as well!

Emotional Health

Emotional health is a pivotal aspect of spiritual growth in Christ, playing a crucial role in maturing as a believer. As we navigate the path of emotional maturity, we realize the importance of emotional balance, as our journey with Jesus helps us move from hypersensitivity or 'emotional numbness' towards healthy emotional processing. Emotionally healthy individuals can experience feelings without letting them lead to irrational responses. Furthermore, emotional health encompasses not only self-awareness but also the ability to recognize and respond to the emotions of others. Below are several components to reflect upon in your time with Jesus:

1. Emotional Awareness (Psalm 139:23-24 ESV):

"Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts! And see if there be any grievous way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting." Reflect on your emotional reactions to various situations. Do you permit yourself to experience your feelings? Invite Jesus into this process of self-discovery and let Him guide you.

2. Processing Emotions (Psalm 55:22 ESV):

"Cast your burden on the Lord, and he will sustain you; he will never permit the righteous to be moved." Are you reactive or responsive to your emotions? Are your reactions led by you or the Holy Spirit? It is essential to process emotions healthily rather than reacting impulsively.

3. Understanding Emotional Triggers (Psalm 147:3 ESV):

"He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds." Do you understand what triggers your emotional responses, and do you respond productively rather than reactively? Have you allowed the Lord to illuminate areas of sensitivity in your heart?

4. Setting Emotional Boundaries (Proverbs 4:23 ESV):

"Keep your heart with all vigilance, for from it flow the springs of life." Just like physical boundaries, emotional boundaries are essential to maintaining a healthy emotional state. Reflect on whether you've established necessary emotional guardrails.

5. Facing Challenges Emotionally (Psalm 34:18 ESV):

"The Lord is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit." Assess your ability to face challenging situations rationally, without resorting to emotional 'numbness' or speeding past negative feelings. Remember, the Lord is always near in these moments.

6. Empathy (Romans 12:15 ESV):

"Rejoice with those who rejoice, weep with those who weep." Are you tuned into the emotional states of those around you? Empathy, the ability to understand and share the feelings of others, is a key characteristic of emotional health.

As you reflect on these components, remember that Jesus is with you, helping you understand and develop your emotional health. Don't forget to grade yourself in each category, and set SMART goals for each as well!

Physical Health

Physical health, an integral aspect of our overall well-being, significantly impacts not only our daily functioning but also our spiritual, mental, and emotional health. A well-maintained physical state enables us to fulfill our daily tasks and God's divine calling for our lives with more vitality and less exhaustion. As the Scripture reminds us, our bodies are temples of the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 6:19-20), thus, the state of our physical health reflects the respect and care we afford to these divine residences.

Poor physical health can potentially impair our mental and emotional well-being, allowing for seeds of self-doubt and negative self-perception to take root. Furthermore, it might lead to a range of health issues, including those illnesses often referred to as 'generational.' Yet, combined with the power of prayer and spiritual warfare, conscious alterations in our dietary habits can help break these generational chains. This synergy of faith and action plays a critical role in our journey toward improved health.

As we explore the key components of physical health, let us invite God's guidance, seeking to understand our current state in comparison to the previous year, and discerning His vision for our health in the upcoming year.

1. Nutrition:

Reflect on your dietary habits. What types of foods do you consume? At what times and how often do you eat? How much water do you drink daily? (Psalm 104:14)

2. Physical Activity:

This encompasses not only gym routines but also outdoor activities such as hiking, walking, and running — anything that elevates your heart rate and challenges your body's physical limits. (1 Timothy 4:8)

3. Rest:

Consider your sleep patterns. Do you get adequate, quality sleep? Rest is vital for both mental sharpness and physical recovery. (Psalm 127:2)

4. Substance Use:

Evaluate your usage of substances like drugs, alcohol, and tobacco. The scripture reminds us that our bodies are the dwelling place of the Holy Spirit. What would He find within you? Understand the short and long-term effects of these substances on your physical health. (1 Corinthians 3:16-17)

As you reflect on these components, remember that Jesus is with you, helping you understand and grow healthier physically as well. Don't forget to grade yourself in each category, and set SMART goals for each as well!

Relational health

Relational health focuses on our ability to establish and maintain fulfilling relationships. It examines the quality of connections we form and nurture with ourselves and others. Our capacity to foster healthy relationships is intrinsically linked to our spiritual, mental, emotional, and physical wellbeing. An imbalance in any of these areas can disrupt the harmony in our relationships.

As we delve into the five critical facets of relational health, let's seek the Holy Spirit's guidance and clarity:

1. Relationship with Self:

This foundational relationship encompasses your understanding of self, personal interests, and most importantly, your identity in Christ as a cherished daughter or son of God. It forms the basis for all other relationships in your life. "For we are God's handiwork, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance for us to do." (Ephesians 2:10, ESV)

2. Relationships with Immediate Family:

These relationships with your significant others, siblings, and parents are often the closest and most impactful. Are you fostering these relationships with Christlike love? Are past hurts or circumstances still influencing how you navigate these relationships? "Above all, keep loving one another earnestly, since love covers a multitude of sins." (1 Peter 4:8, ESV)

3. Relationships with Extended Family:

How well are you shining Christ's light into your relationships with extended family members such as cousins, aunts, and uncles? "So then, as we have an opportunity, let us do good to everyone, and especially to those who are of the household of faith." (Galatians 6:10, ESV)

4. Relationships with Peers, Coworkers, and Friends:

Examine the influence of these relationships on your spiritual growth. Are these connections drawing you closer to Christ or serving as stumbling blocks in your faith journey? "Whoever walks with the wise becomes wise, but the companion of fools will suffer harm." (Proverbs 13:20, ESV)

5. Relationships with Strangers:

How receptive are you to serving God through interactions with strangers or unexpected acquaintances? "Do not neglect to show hospitality to strangers, for thereby some have entertained angels unawares." (Hebrews 13:2, ESV)

Remember to grade yourself in the categories as the Holy Spirit guides you!

Stewardship

Stewardship, in a reflective context, extends beyond mere financial management. It's about how we manage all the gifts and resources God has entrusted to us. As we explore the following four areas of stewardship, let's consider our growth compared to the previous year and anticipate where God wants us to be in the future:

1. Time Management:

Have you made progress in optimizing the way you use your time? Are you dedicating adequate time to prayer, studying the Bible, serving others, and other aspects of Christian living? "Look carefully then how you walk, not as unwise but as wise, making the best use of the time, because the days are evil." (Ephesians 5:15-16, ESV)

2. Energy Management:

Time management is ineffective without energy management. Are you ensuring that your energy levels are sufficiently maintained to carry out the tasks set before you? "For he gives to his beloved sleep." (Psalms 127:2b, ESV)

3. Relationship Management:

How well are you maintaining the various relationships in your life? This area is distinct from relational health, focusing more on the active management of friendships, business relationships, etc. "Do not be deceived: Bad company ruins good morals." (1 Corinthians 15:33, ESV)

4. Resource Management:

How effectively are you utilizing the resources God has blessed you with? Are you using your talents and abilities for His glory? "As each has received a gift, use it to serve one another, as good stewards of God's varied grace." (1 Peter 4:10, ESV)

5. Financial Management:

How do you manage the finances God has entrusted to you? Are you consistently tithing and supporting your local church and those in need? "Each one must give as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver." (2 Corinthians 9:7, ESV)

Remember, you're evaluating yourself on a scale of 1-10 in each of these subcategories, and calculating the average to obtain your overall score for each category. Following this, you'll set SMART (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound) goals for the next 3 to 6 months to help you grow in each area.

Closing

As we come to the conclusion of this time of introspection and growth, having sat down with Jesus to traverse the depths of ourselves, I want to leave you with a word of encouragement. It's true that the process of self-evaluation and goal-setting can be demanding and even overwhelming. However, this journey was not designed to be merely a self-help exercise. Instead, my prayer is that this exploration ignited the Scriptures in your life, prompting the Holy Spirit to engage with you in ways that awaken your desire for a deeper relationship with God. I firmly believe that the roots of good health and sound stewardship are intertwined with your dedicated time spent with Him.

So, let's conclude our session with a heartfelt prayer. Father, first and foremost, I repent for the numerous times I have fallen short and failed to seek your presence. I am grateful to you for preparing a banquet for me amid the battleground of my life. I am grateful that through my relationship with you, I have all that I need for a life of godliness.

Jesus, I thank you for the price you paid on the cross for me, for the blood you shed - for I know it is because of your sacrifice that I can call upon my Heavenly Father. I believe in your victorious triumph over death, and that by your blood shed on the cross, my sins are washed clean.

I express my gratitude for the resurrection power of the Holy Spirit within me, which I possess because of your resurrection three days after your death. I am thankful for the promises of long life, robust health, nourishing relationships, and never-ending provision filled with your favor as I grow in my knowledge of you.

I know that by taking the step to sit at the table, you have revealed to me the anointing you have placed on my life, and my cup will overflow.

I declare my love for you and commit to serving you all the days of my life. In Jesus' name, Amen.

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path." (Psalms 119:105, ESV) May this light guide you as you continue on your journey of spiritual development.